the 1890s, connecting Kampala in Uganda with Mombassa in Kenya. This workforce comprised nearly 40,000 Indians (represented by actor Om Puri in the movie), drawn mostly from Punjab on indenture contracts of three to five years.[22] The terrain was harsh, the lions were hungry and mortality rates were high during the construction of what the detractors called the 'lunatic line'. Once built, however, it transformed landscapes as towns and cities grew around it. While most of the workforce that built the railways went back to India, a few thousand stayed back and staffed the railways. Gujarati shopkeepers, called *dukka wallah*s, began setting up trading posts all along the railway line, moving towards the interiors of Africa for the first time.

Indian migration picked up during the inter-war period as British colonial rule consolidated in Tanganyika, now Tanzania, previously ruled by the Germans. East Africa attracted a large number of people from western India into a wide range of occupations in the services sector. Some Indian cotton ginning firms were also set up during this period. From roughly 50,000 in 1921, the Indian population doubled in size by 1939 and reached nearly 3,00,000 by 1969. However, after Independence in the 1960s, the East African states nationalized large parts of the economy and became openly hostile towards the immigrant Indian population. Just as Indian nationalists had blamed British capital for draining Indian wealth, African nationalists blamed Indian capitalists for draining African wealth.

The hostility reached its peak on 5 August 1972, when General Idi Amin, the then President of Uganda, delivered his 'Asian Farewell Speech'. In his view, the Indians had arrived to build the railways, and since the line was complete, they would have to go back. Asians, mainly Indians, were given an ultimatum to leave within ninety days. Within a few months, nearly the entire Indian population of 50,000 left, a scene vividly portrayed in *The Last King of Scotland*, the title of which referred to Amin's fetish for Scottish culture. A widespread fear gripped the Indian population of the wider region of East Africa, just as the Tsavo lions had instilled fear several decades earlier. As a result, a mass exodus took place as the 'twice